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PREPARED FOR SVISH ·
TRIVANDRUM ·
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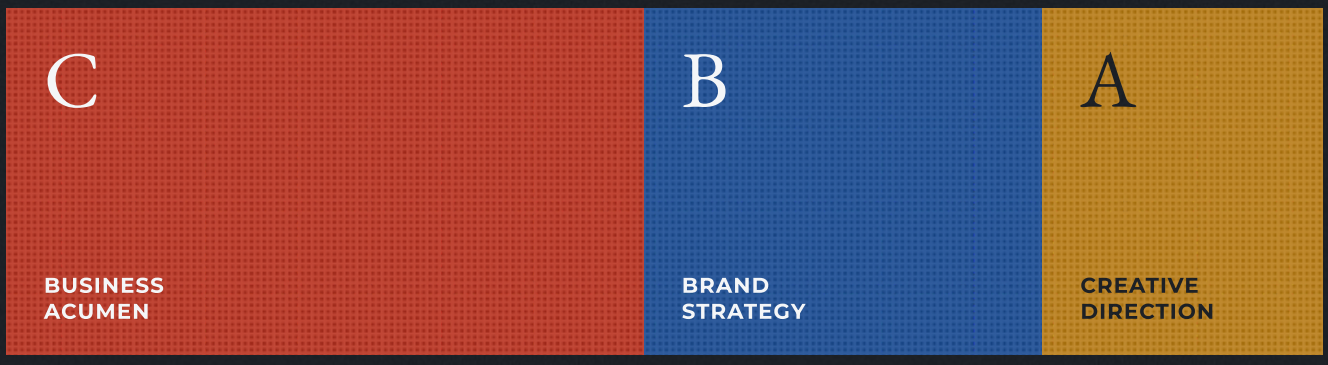
The *Operator's* Curriculum

Creative direction, brand strategy and business judgement. A 12-month workbook with what to memorise, what to practise, and what to prove.



Indian tax and legal points in this workbook are from memory and are marked *verify*. Confirm them with a CA or lawyer before you act.

Built around *where you are*

You have the eye. What decides whether Elswheir lasts is pricing, cash, client choice and contracts. So the order is **business acumen first, brand strategy second,** and creative direction refined alongside. Strategy and business acumen are one skill seen from two sides: thinking about your client's business, and thinking about your own.

YOUR STARTING POSITION

Visual & concept judgement	**STRONG**	5+ years film and animation concept work
Audience psychology	**RAW EDGE**	BA psychology, not yet turned into written deliverables
Content strategy	**PARTIAL**	Tactical level, one step below brand strategy
Positioning & platforms	**GAP**	Track B builds this
Financial command	**GAP**	Track C builds this
Proof of effectiveness	**BIGGEST GAP**	One anchor client and no case studies with numbers yet

RULES FOR THE WAY YOUR MIND WORKS

1. **Output, not input.** For every hour of reading, spend two hours applying it to a live client. Reading feels like progress. It isn't.
2. **Work on two skills at a time, no more:** one business skill and one strategy skill.
3. **A skill counts as done only when its output exists.** Tick the box, not the chapter.
4. **When a week collapses,** protect just two habits: the receivables check and one practice session.
5. **When you're blocked,** walk, game or sleep first. Come back after. Don't force output.
6. **Teach it back.** After each skill, write a 200-word post in your own words. It's retrieval practice, and it doubles as Elswheir LinkedIn content.

THE MASTERY LOOP: RUN IT ON EVERY EXERCISE

1. **Predict**
   Write what you expect and how confident you are.
2. **Do**
   Ship it to a real client with real stakes.
3. **Measure**
   Record what actually happened, in numbers.
4. **Review**
   Where was your model wrong? Write the rule.
5. **Critique**
   Monthly, with someone more senior than you.

YOUR FIRST SEVEN DAYS

- ☐ *Day 1.* List every unpaid invoice with its age in days (C4).
- ☐ *Day 2.* Pull 3 months of bank statements and build the rough P&L (C1).
- ☐ *Day 3.* Work out AIME's share of your revenue (C2).
- ☐ *Day 4.* Book the CA session and send the agenda from C6.
- ☐ *Day 5.* Start the decision journal with one open decision (C7).
- ☐ *Day 6.* Ask AIME for enquiry and enrolment numbers for the last two seasons (B1).
- ☐ *Day 7.* Rest. Walk. Let it settle.

The skill *tree*

Read it from the bottom up. Roots feed everything above them. A ★ **shared skill** builds two or more tracks with one round of practice, so do those first. The small notes show where a skill depends on another track.

C · BUSINESS ACUMEN

- **C7** Decision quality — capstone · uses C1–C6
- **C5** Sales & negotiation ★ — → A5
- **C3** Pricing & value ★ — → A5
- **C6** Contracts & tax ★ — → A8
- **C4** Cash & collections
- **C2** Unit economics ★ — → B1 · A6
- **C1** Financial literacy — unlocks most of the tree

B · BRAND STRATEGY

- **B9** Case studies ★ — proof for all tracks
- **B8** Effectiveness — needs C1
- **B6** Architecture & naming
- **B5** Brand platform
- **B7** Creative brief ★ — → A1 · A2
- **B4** Positioning
- **B3** Insight ★ — → A1
- **B2** Research — needs R2
- **B1** Client diagnosis — needs C1 · C2

A · CREATIVE DIRECTION

- **A5** Selling the work — needs C3 · C5
- **A8** Rights & legal — needs C6
- **A6** Production economics — needs C2
- **A7** Systems & guidelines
- **A4** Killing work
- **A3** Feedback language
- **A2** Briefing others — needs B7
- **A1** Idea vs execution — needs B3 · B7
- **A9** Taste calibration — daily, throughout

Roots

- **R1** Clear writing: one-page thinking
- **R2** People psychology: you have this
- **R3** Numbers literacy

The *critical path*

This is the fastest route through the tree. Each step unlocks the next. **A9 taste calibration** runs underneath the whole time, at 15 minutes a day.

WK 1–3	WK 3–5	WK 5–10	WK 10–14	WK 14–20	WK 20–26	MO 7–9	MO 9–12
C1	C2★	B1–B3	B4 B7★	C3★ C5★	C4 C6★	B5 B6 B8	B9★ C7
Financial literacy	Unit economics on Elswheir	AIME diagnosis, interviews, insight	Positioning and the one-page brief	Pricing and sales; unlocks A5	Cash, contracts; covers A8	Platforms, naming, effectiveness	Case studies and decision quality

A9 Taste calibration: a 5-line breakdown of one great piece of work every day, all year

OPERATING RHYTHM

WHEN	TIME	WHAT
Daily	15 min	One breakdown (A9) and one insight reverse-engineered (B3)
Weekly	30 min	Receivables check, pipeline review, decision-journal entries
Weekly	2–3 hrs	Applied practice on one live client
Monthly	1 hr	Money review (template p. 17) and journal review
Monthly	1 hr	Outside critique with AD PROPHETS or a senior strategist
Quarterly	Half day	Strategy review, scorecard, one finished case study

HOW TO READ A MODULE

Memorise	Five or six points to know cold. Read them aloud once a day while the skill is active. Quiz yourself with the right side covered.
Apply	Exercises on your real clients, each with an output and a time box. The output is the proof the skill is learned.
Done when	The test for moving on. Tick it only when it's true, not when the reading is finished.
Needs / Unlocks	Where the skill sits in the tree. Don't start a skill before the ones it needs.

Minimum viable week: receivables check and one practice session. Everything else can slip. These two can't.

Track C · Business acumen

Thinking about your own business: money, pricing, deals, risk. Start here.

C1 Financial literacy

Unlocks **C2 · C4 · C6 · B1 · B8**

Every other skill on this page needs numbers to stand on. You can't price, choose clients or judge a bet you can't measure.

Memorise

1. Revenue is vanity, profit is sanity, *cash is reality.*
2. Profit = revenue − all costs, **including a fair salary for you.** If you don't pay yourself, the profit isn't real.
3. Gross margin = (revenue − direct project costs) ÷ revenue. Direct costs are tool credits, freelancers, vendors and partner shares.
4. Break-even = monthly fixed costs ÷ gross margin %.
5. Runway = cash in bank ÷ monthly burn.
6. GST you collect is **not your money.** Keep it separate the day it arrives.

Apply

Build the Elswheir P&L

Last 3 months, every rupee in and out: Higgsfield and AI subscriptions, freelancers, partner splits with AD PROPHETS and AEVORO, internet, equipment.

OUTPUT · ONE-SHEET P&L — 2 HRS

Find your break-even

Fixed monthly costs plus your minimum salary, divided by your margin. Write the number on a card above your desk.

OUTPUT · ONE NUMBER — 30 MIN

Set up a tax account

Open a separate account for GST and tax. Move a fixed % of every receipt into it. Ask your CA what the % should be.

OUTPUT · STANDING INSTRUCTION — 1 HR

☐ **Done when you can state last month's revenue, margin, cash, receivables and break-even from memory.**

C2 Unit economics ★ SHARED

Unlocks **C3 · B1 · A6**

This tells you which work actually makes you money. The same lens becomes client diagnosis (B1) and production economics (A6).

Memorise

1. Effective rate = fee ÷ actual hours. **Use it to diagnose, never to price.**
2. Chase *margin* per project, not revenue per project.
3. CAC is the time and money it takes to win a client. LTV is the margin earned over the whole relationship.
4. Healthy LTV is roughly 3× CAC or more. This is a SaaS rule of thumb; use it as a rough guide.
5. If one client is over ~40% of revenue, losing them is an existential risk (rough threshold).
6. Revisions silently eat your margin.

Apply

Review your last 5 projects

AIME, C0C0N promo, Bodhini and two more. For each: quoted vs actual hours, tool credits, revision rounds, final margin. Rank them by margin.

OUTPUT · RANKED TABLE — 3 HRS

Check your AIME dependence

What share of the last 12 months' revenue came from AIME? If it's over 40%, set a 90-day target to land one more retainer.

OUTPUT · % PLUS TARGET — 45 MIN

Cost per finished second

Total production cost of your AI video pipeline ÷ seconds delivered. This is your internal floor for any quote.

OUTPUT · FLOOR RATE — 1 HR

☐ **Done when you know your three most and least profitable kinds of work, and why.**

C3 Pricing & value ★ SHARED

Unlocks **C5 · A5**

Value-based pricing is your stated model. This module turns it from a belief into a method you can defend in front of a client.

Memorise

1. Price to the *value of the outcome,* not your effort.
2. Value = what the result is worth in the **client's currency:** enrolments, sales, price premium.
3. Always offer three options. The middle is your target and the top sets the anchor.
4. Never cut price without removing scope.
5. Write your walk-away number **before** the call.
6. If you win more than ~70% of pitches, you are probably underpriced (rough heuristic).

Apply

Do the AIME value maths

Fee per student × the extra enrolments a campaign could plausibly drive = the value at stake. Decide the share of it you can defend, and write down your reasoning.

OUTPUT · VALUE SHEET — 1 HR

Price the Dubai client in three tiers

Essential / Signature / Atelier, priced in AED, with the top tier as the anchor. Check the AED–INR rate on the day.

OUTPUT · 3-TIER PROPOSAL — 2 HRS

Retire the rate card

Rewrite your services as packages, each with scope, number of revisions, usage rights and timeline.

OUTPUT · PACKAGE SHEET — 2 HRS

☐ **Done when every proposal states the client's value before your price.**

C4 Cash & collections

Unlocks **C7**

Profitable studios still die of empty bank accounts. This module is mostly habit, not theory.

Memorise

1. Work never runs **ahead of payment.**
2. Take a 40–50% advance on project work and bill the rest by milestone.
3. Invoice the day a milestone is hit. Follow up on fixed days.
4. Money owed to you above one month of revenue is a red flag.
5. Put a late-payment clause in every contract.
6. Keep a 3–6 month buffer covering personal and studio costs (rough guide).

Apply

List what you're owed

Every unpaid invoice today, with its age in days. Chase anything over 30 days this week.

OUTPUT · RECEIVABLES LIST — 30 MIN

Write three follow-up templates

A friendly one for day 3, a firm one for day 15, a final notice for day 30. Write them once and reuse them.

OUTPUT · 3 TEMPLATES — 45 MIN

Calculate your runway

Cash in bank ÷ (studio plus personal monthly costs). If it's under 3 months, that becomes priority one.

OUTPUT · MONTHS OF RUNWAY — 20 MIN

☐ **Done when receivables stay under one month of revenue for a full quarter.**

C5 Sales & negotiation ★ SHARED

Unlocks **A5**

You already read people well. This module turns that into a repeatable process, and covers your partner deals.

Memorise

1. Ask before you pitch: **problem, impact, budget, decision-maker, timeline.**
2. Know your BATNA, your best alternative if the deal dies. The stronger it is, the calmer you negotiate.
3. *Trade, don't give.* Every concession should get you something back.
4. Silence is a tool. Let the client fill it.
5. Name the emotion: "It sounds like timing is the real concern."
6. For every partnership, write down what each side gives and what each side gets.

Apply

Script your discovery call

Run the five questions on the next lead and log the answers in a sales sheet with a dated next step.

OUTPUT · SALES LOG ROW — EACH CALL

Map partner economics

AD PROPHETS, AEVORO, and the Bodhini alliance: who brings leads, who delivers, the % splits, who owns the client relationship. Mark any imbalance.

OUTPUT · ONE-PAGE MAP — 1.5 HRS

Prepare objections for Girl Rising

Write the three objections they are most likely to raise to your producer pitch, with your answer to each.

OUTPUT · OBJECTION SHEET — 45 MIN

☐ **Done when you never end a sales call without knowing the budget signal and who decides.**

C6 Contracts, tax & compliance ★ SHARED

Unlocks **A8 · C7**

Mistakes here are expensive and hard to undo. This module also covers creative usage rights (A8). Verify every point below with a CA or lawyer.

Memorise

1. No work starts without **signed scope plus advance.**
2. IP transfers only on *full payment.*
3. Price usage rights separately by medium, territory and term. Cap your liability at the fee.
4. GST: registration is generally required above ₹20 lakh aggregate turnover for services. *From memory, verify.*
5. Exports such as the Dubai work may be zero-rated under a LUT if they meet the export conditions. Keep the FIRC/FIRA. *Verify.*
6. Reconcile TDS against Form 26AS/AIS every quarter, or you lose the credit.

Apply

Book a CA session

Agenda: GST status, whether 44ADA applies to your work, which TDS sections clients use, the LUT for Dubai, export paperwork.

OUTPUT · WRITTEN ANSWERS — 1 HR

Get a master contract

One master service agreement plus a SOW template, drafted by a lawyer. Do it once and reuse it.

OUTPUT · TEMPLATES — LAWYER FEE

Find what isn't written down

Check the AIME and Dubai arrangements: is any scope, payment term or rights clause only verbal?

OUTPUT · GAP LIST — 1 HR

☐ **Done when you know your quarterly tax dates and every active client has a signed agreement.**

C7 Decision quality

Unlocks **Everything**

This is the capstone, and it's what being a "grounded but successful" businessman comes down to: deciding well on incomplete information, again and again.

Memorise

1. Judge a decision by its **process,** not its outcome. Good calls can still lose.
2. One-way doors go slow, two-way doors go fast.
3. Assume 1.5× the cost and 2× the time. Plan cash around that.
4. Grounded means protecting the downside. Successful means taking *sized* bets on the upside.
5. Make many small, survivable bets rather than a few large ones.
6. Write down what you expect **before** you know the result.

Apply

Pre-mortem the backup model

Kerala healthcare institute: "It's 2028 and it failed. Why?" List 10 reasons, rank the top 3, and design the cheapest test for the riskiest one.

OUTPUT · PRE-MORTEM SHEET — 1.5 HRS

Keep a decision journal

Log every decision above ₹50,000 or longer than 3 months, using the template at the back. Review it monthly.

OUTPUT · JOURNAL — 10 MIN EACH

Run a quarterly review

Where did revenue come from? What should you stop, start, continue? What is the single biggest risk?

OUTPUT · ONE PAGE — HALF DAY

☐ **Done when you have 12 months of journal entries and can name your three most common mistakes in judgement.**

C7 · THE TWELVE MODELS TO MEMORISE

Cover the right two columns and quiz yourself. Then name one live decision each model applies to this week.

Opportunity cost	**What am I not doing if I say yes?** A low-fee project vs time spent on the Dubai wedge.
Base rates	**How does this usually go for people like me?** A new revenue line: assume it is slower and smaller.
Second-order effects	**And then what?** A discount for one client becomes the price everyone expects.
Inversion	**How would I guarantee this fails?** Then avoid exactly that.
Pre-mortem	**It's a year later and it failed. Why?** Run it before any big commitment.
Expected value	**Probability × payoff, compared across options.** Which pitches deserve your week.
Reversibility	**Is this a one-way or a two-way door?** Hiring, equity and long contracts are one-way doors.
Margin of safety	**What if it costs 1.5× and takes 2× as long?** Cash planning, launch timing.
Concentration	**What breaks if one thing fails?** One client, one partner, one platform.
Incentives	**What does each party actually gain?** Partner splits, client stakeholders.
Sunk cost	**Would I start this today, knowing what I know?** Long pitches going nowhere.
Circle of competence	**Do I actually know this, or do I just feel confident?** Healthcare, trading, new markets.

Track B · Brand strategy

Thinking about your client's business: finding the truth, defining the brand, proving it worked.

B1 Client business diagnosis

Needs **C1 · C2**
Unlocks **B2**

Most marketing problems are business problems in disguise. Find the real one before you touch a brief.

Memorise

1. Ask: how do they make money, and **where does it leak?**
2. Map the funnel: awareness → enquiry → conversion → retention → referral.
3. Find the *constraint,* the one stage that limits growth. Work there.
4. Seasonality decides timing. For NEET/JEE that means results season and admission windows.
5. A client asking for "more reels" rarely needs more reels.

Apply

AIME on one page

Fee structure, cost per enquiry, enquiry-to-enrolment conversion, competitor fees, seasonal calendar. Circle the constraint.

OUTPUT · DIAGNOSIS PAGE — 3 HRS

Bodhini on one page

Channels, repeat-purchase rate, margin per bottle, who buys vs who uses. Ask AD PROPHETS for the data.

OUTPUT · DIAGNOSIS PAGE — 2 HRS

☐ **Done when you can explain each client's growth constraint in one sentence.**

B2 Research

Needs **R2 · B1**
Unlocks **B3**

Your psychology degree is a real advantage here. This is where it starts showing up in client deliverables.

Memorise

1. Ask about **past behaviour,** not future intentions.
2. Open with: *"Tell me about the last time you…"*
3. 5–8 interviews usually surface most patterns (common qualitative practice).
4. Keep what people **say, do and feel** separate.
5. Don't lead and don't pitch. Watch for social-desirability bias, especially with parents.

Apply

Interview six AIME families

Students and parents, in Malayalam, Tamil or English, recorded with consent. Synthesise into patterns, tensions and verbatim quotes.

OUTPUT · SYNTHESIS BOARD — 1 WEEK

Audit five competitors

Five coaching institutes' ads: claims, tone, visual codes. Plot them on two axes and find the empty space.

OUTPUT · COMPETITOR MAP — 3 HRS

☐ **Done when you've produced a synthesis a stranger could act on.**

B3 Insight ★ SHARED

Needs **B2**
Unlocks **B4 · A1**

This is the hinge between strategy and creative. A sharp insight makes your ideas (A1) sharper at the same time.

Memorise

1. An observation is not an insight.
2. Insight = a truth + a **tension** + the reaction "huh, that's true".
3. Formula: *[Audience] wants [X], but [tension], because [deeper why].*
4. Test every one: is it true, non-obvious, and something the brand can act on?
5. The best insights live in the **contradictions** in your research.

Apply

Write 20, keep 3

From the AIME interviews, write 20 candidate insights in the formula. Cut to 3 and test each against the three questions.

OUTPUT · 3 INSIGHTS — 2 HRS

Daily reverse-engineering

For one ad you see each day, write the insight behind it in the formula. Five minutes.

OUTPUT · INSIGHT LOG — 5 MIN/DAY

☐ **Done when your insights make clients pause before they nod.**

B4 Positioning

Needs **B3**
Unlocks **B5 · B7**

Positioning is deciding what to give up. It applies to every client, and to Elswheir itself.

Memorise

1. *For* [target] *who* [need], [brand] *is the* [frame of reference] *that* [difference] *because* [proof].
2. Positioning is sacrifice: choosing **who you're not for.**
3. The frame of reference sets what you get compared against.
4. The difference must matter to the customer and be defensible.
5. Proof beats claims.

Apply

Position Elswheir

Write the statement, then a "we are not" list. For example: not an AI content mill, not a cheap reel factory.

OUTPUT · STATEMENT + NOT-LIST — 1.5 HRS

Position AIME and the Dubai house

One statement each. For the couture house, map it against three other Dubai couture labels first.

OUTPUT · 2 STATEMENTS — 2 HRS

☐ **Done when each statement fits in one breath and excludes someone.**

B5 Brand platform

Needs **B4**
Unlocks **B6**

The platform is the single page that keeps every future asset consistent, including work that isn't made by you.

Memorise

1. Purpose: **only if it's true.** No purpose is better than a fake one.
2. Write values as behaviours: "We show the cost before the work", not "Transparency".
3. Personality: three adjectives, each with a *"but not"* (bold, but not loud).
4. Messages: one core message, three supporting, proof for each.
5. If it doesn't fit on one page, the choices haven't been made yet.

Apply

Three platforms

One page each for AIME, Bodhini and Elswheir. Use "this, not that" pairs for personality and voice.

OUTPUT · 3 PAGES — 1 DAY

Pressure test

Give a platform to a freelancer with no other briefing. Does what they produce feel on-brand?

OUTPUT · TEST RESULT — 1 WEEK

☐ **Done when someone else can make on-brand work from your page alone.**

B6 Architecture & naming

Needs **B5**
Unlocks —

You have a live naming project right now. Set the criteria first and generate names second.

Memorise

1. Three architectures: branded house, house of brands, endorsed.
2. Name types: descriptive, invented, metaphor, founder, acronym.
3. Criteria: distinct, easy to say, ownable (trademark and domain), clean in every target language, room to grow.
4. **Write the criteria before you generate names.**
5. Test names out loud with people from the target market, not with friends.

Apply

Dragonfly agency names

Criteria first, including *must not read as India or MENA.* Generate 50, screen against the criteria, check trademark and domain, then test pronunciation with 5 people in the target markets.

OUTPUT · SHORTLIST OF 3 — 1 WEEK

Map AIME × Arcane

Is Arcane a sub-brand, endorsed, or separate? Draw it, and write the rule for when the AIME name appears.

OUTPUT · ARCHITECTURE MAP — 1 HR

☐ **Done when the shortlist passes every criterion on paper.**

B7 The creative brief ★ SHARED

The brief is where strategy turns into creative work. Writing better briefs also makes you a better director (A1, A2).

Needs **B4 · R1**
Unlocks **A1 · A2**

Memorise

1. One page, always.
2. Single-minded proposition = **one thing.** Not two.
3. A brief is a *springboard, not a fence.*
4. If you can't say it in one line, the strategy isn't finished.
5. Always include what success looks like: a metric.

Apply

Rewrite one brief

Rewrite the next AIME or C0C0N brief on one page. Hand it to a partner and count the revision rounds.

OUTPUT · BRIEF + COUNT — 1.5 HRS

The stranger test

Give a brief to someone with no context. Can they explain the job back to you in 30 seconds?

OUTPUT · PASS / FAIL — 15 MIN

☐ **Done when your briefs average two revision rounds or fewer.**

B8 Growth & effectiveness

This is how you prove your work moves the business, and it's what justifies value-based pricing.

Needs **C1**
Unlocks **B9**

Memorise

1. Brands grow mainly by reaching **more buyers,** including light buyers (Sharp).
2. Build mental availability (easy to think of) and physical availability (easy to buy).
3. Distinctive assets such as colours, characters and sounds only work if you keep them *consistent.*
4. Balance long-term brand building with short-term activation. Binet & Field's ~60:40 is an average that varies by category. *From memory.*
5. Agree the metrics **before** the work starts.

Apply

Set AIME's metrics

Before the next campaign, agree on three: enquiries, cost per enquiry, enrolments. Build a simple tracker you both see.

OUTPUT · METRIC SHEET — 1 HR

Audit Bodhini's assets

What is consistent across every touchpoint? What keeps changing? Recommend the 2–3 assets to lock in.

OUTPUT · ASSET AUDIT — 2 HRS

☐ **Done when every active client has agreed metrics on paper.**

B9 Case-study writing ★ SHARED

Case studies are the proof for all three tracks. They are what your next client, partner or investor will judge you on.

Needs **B8**
Unlocks **Proof**

Memorise

1. Structure: problem → insight → idea → execution → **results** → learning.
2. *Numbers, or it didn't happen.*
3. A short client quote adds trust that design can't.
4. Write for the client you want next, not the one you had.
5. Check the NDA before naming anyone.

Apply

The AIME case

Done by Q3. One page plus a 60-second film cut. Get the enrolment and enquiry numbers from AIME in writing.

OUTPUT · CASE STUDY — 1 DAY

The Dubai case

Ask permission early. If you can't name them, write an anonymised version with the numbers kept.

OUTPUT · CASE STUDY — 1 DAY

☐ **Done when you have two cases with numbers you can send without explanation.**

STRATEGY FORMULAS: LEARN THEM BY HEART

Insight	[Audience] wants [X], but [tension], because [deeper why].
Positioning	For [target] who [need], [brand] is the [frame] that [difference] because [proof].
Proposition	One thing. If it has an "and", cut it in half.
Personality	Adjective, but not [its excess]. ×3.
Case study	Problem → insight → idea → execution → results → learning.
Funnel	Awareness → enquiry → conversion → retention → referral. Work on the constraint.
Interview opener	"Tell me about the last time you…"

YOUR UNFAIR EDGE: PSYCHOLOGY YOU ALREADY OWN, MAPPED TO THE WORK

Anchoring	The first number sets the frame. Show the top tier first.	C3
Loss aversion	Frame the cost of inaction (empty seats, missed season) before your price.	C5
Social desirability	Parents say what sounds right. Ask what they *did*.	B2
Availability heuristic	What comes to mind first gets chosen. That is mental availability.	B8
Social proof	Case studies and named results do the selling for you.	B9
Confirmation bias	Yours. Look for the interview that breaks your favourite insight.	B3 · C7
Planning fallacy	Yours too. Add 50% to time and cost estimates by default.	C7

Track A · Creative direction

You already have the craft. These are the unglamorous skills that separate a senior CD from a strong artist. Rate yourself 1–5 on each and work on anything 3 or below.

A1 Idea vs execution

If it can't be said in one sentence, *it isn't an idea yet.*

Apply Before any frames for Els Prophecy or C0C0N, write the idea as one line. Keep the line pinned above the edit timeline.

NEEDS B3 · B7

☐

A2 Briefing others

Revision rounds measure *your brief,* not their talent.

Apply Track revisions per brief and aim for two or fewer. Keep a reusable prompt-brief template for Nano Banana via Higgsfield.

NEEDS B7

☐

A3 Feedback language

Name the problem and the goal. *Let them find the fix.*

Apply Rewrite your last 10 feedback notes as "X doesn't yet feel Y, because Z."

☐

A4 Killing work

Your loyalty is to the brief, *not the frame.*

Apply Log one thing you cut per project and why. Review the log quarterly.

☐

A5 Selling the work

Problem → insight → idea → execution. *Never open with visuals.*

Apply Before every presentation, write the three objections you expect. Afterwards, note which ones actually came up.

NEEDS C3 · C5

☐

A6 Production economics

Know your *cost per finished second.*

Apply Keep a cost log per project: hours, credits, vendors, revisions. Compare it with the quote.

NEEDS C2

☐

A7 Systems & guidelines

Work nobody else can extend *stops growing when you step away.*

Apply Ship a two-page mini guideline with every identity or campaign project.

☐

A8 Rights & legal

Price usage separately: *medium, territory, term.*

Apply Add a rights clause to every quote. Ask a lawyer about AI-output copyright in India, music and font licences, and talent releases.

NEEDS C6

☐

A9 Taste calibration

Taste is *judgement you can put into words.*

Apply Every day, write 5 lines on one piece of award-winning work: insight, idea, craft choice, the emotion it targets, and the bias it uses.

NEEDS R2

☐

Twelve months, *four proofs*

Each quarter ends with something you can show. If a quarter slips, move the dates, but don't skip the proof.

	BUSINESS	STRATEGY	CREATIVE DIRECTION	PROOF BY QUARTER END
Q1 Nov–Jan	C1, C4. Money review habit. CA session on GST, TDS and the tax regime.	B1–B3. AIME diagnosis, interviews, insight.	Brief template. Feedback rewrite.	**3 monthly P&Ls. AIME research synthesis.**
Q2 Feb–Apr	C2, C3. Unit economics. Pricing reset on new proposals.	B4–B5. Positioning and platforms for AIME, Bodhini and Elswheir.	Selling the work. Three-objection drill.	**3 platforms. New pricing used on 3+ proposals.**
Q3 May–Jul	C5, C6. Sales log. Master contract from a lawyer.	B6–B7. Dragonfly naming. One-page briefs.	Cost log. Rights clauses.	**Signed master contract. AIME case study.**
Q4 Aug–Oct	C7. Quarterly reviews. Pre-mortems on big bets.	B8–B9. Effectiveness metrics. Case writing.	50+ taste breakdowns.	**2 case studies. Annual review of revenue, margin, concentration, win rate.**

READING: ONE BOOK AT A TIME, ONLY ALONGSIDE ITS SKILL

BUSINESS

- *The Personal MBA*, Kaufman · C1–C7
- *Financial Intelligence for Entrepreneurs*, Berman & Knight · C1
- *Profit First*, Michalowicz · C4
- *The Win Without Pitching Manifesto*, Enns · C3
- *Never Split the Difference*, Voss · C5
- *Thinking in Bets*, Duke · C7

STRATEGY

- *Strategy Is Your Words*, Pollard · B3–B7
- *How Brands Grow*, Sharp · B8
- *The Long and the Short of It*, Binet & Field · B8
- *Positioning*, Ries & Trout · B4
- *Zag*, Neumeier · B4
- Effie India, WARC and IPA cases · B9

CREATIVE DIRECTION

- *Hey Whipple, Squeeze This*, Sullivan · A1–A5
- *A Technique for Producing Ideas*, Young · A1
- Cannes Lions, D&AD and One Show case films · A9

Titles are recommended from memory. Check editions and availability.

Templates *to copy*

DECISION JOURNAL: ONE PER DECISION OVER ₹50,000 OR LONGER THAN 3 MONTHS

DATE

DECISION

OPTIONS CONSIDERED

WHAT I EXPECT WILL HAPPEN

CONFIDENCE ____ % ONE-WAY OR TWO-WAY DOOR? REVIEW ON _____

WHAT ACTUALLY HAPPENED

RULE LEARNED

PRE-MORTEM: "IT'S 12 MONTHS LATER AND THIS FAILED. WHY?"

THE BET

TEN REASONS IT FAILED

TOP 3, RANKED BY LIKELIHOOD × DAMAGE

CHEAPEST TEST OF THE RISKIEST ASSUMPTION

MONTHLY MONEY REVIEW: FIRST MONDAY, ONE HOUR

Revenue this month		**Cash in bank**	
Direct costs		**Owed to me (total)**	
Gross margin %		**Oldest unpaid invoice (days)**	
Fixed costs + my salary		**Committed costs, next 3 months**	
Profit		**Runway (months)**	
Top client share %		**Tax & GST account balance**	

ONE THING TO CHANGE NEXT MONTH

QUARTERLY SCORECARD: RATE 1–5

SKILL	Q1	Q2	Q3	Q4
I know my monthly numbers from memory				
Receivables under one month of revenue				
Price set on value; walk-away number defined				
Top client under 40% of revenue				
I write a one-page brief a stranger can use				
I build brand platforms from real research				
I state the idea in one sentence before visuals				
I present problem → insight → idea → execution				
Decision journal kept and reviewed monthly				
Case studies with numbers (count)				

The last row matters most. Clients, partners and your own confidence all rest on it.